

and to prevent or treat pain.

HOW YOU CAN HELP YOUR BABY

Parents whose baby is in a special care unit may be very stressed. They may feel that they have no role in the care of their baby; however, this is not the case. The most important thing you can do for your baby is to start expressing breast milk. Breast milk will nearly always be the best milk for a premature baby and can be stored in a freezer until needed.

You may be able to touch and stroke your baby and can be helped to cuddle while they are on a ventilator. Babies thrive on skin-to-skin contact, called kangaroo care. You'll be encouraged to tuck your baby on your chest inside your shirt so that they can enjoy a close bond. Talking, reading, and singing to your baby help them become familiar with you. You may be able to change their diaper and help with feedings, even if these are through a nasogastric tube.

Spend plenty of time with your baby, especially when breastfeeding since this may help the letdown reflex (see [Taking your baby out](#)), but conserve energy for when you return home with your baby.



NEONATAL UNIT STAFF

Since your baby may spend several weeks in the neonatal unit, you are likely to get to know the staff well.